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AV startup Pronto
acquires off-road
autonomous vehicle rival
SafeAI



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cameras, and artificial intelligence to operate haul trucks autonomously. Pronto also uses [Pollen Mobile](#), a peer-to-peer open source mobile data network the startup launched in 2022 that allows it to exchange data anonymously and at high speeds without relying on legacy carriers. Pollen is used to support sites with little to no connectivity.

Pronto has kept its team fairly lean at about 40 people. The SafeAI acquisition will help Pronto



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The acquisition will also allow Pronto to meet a variety of needs from small quarries to large mines.

Notably, the acquisition will allow Pronto to offer customers a tiered technology portfolio. Pronto is known for its camera-only approach. SafeAI, which was founded in 2017 and raised \$29 million in

Series E multiple lidar. Pronto approach that has integrity



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Five year
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Now, that decision — which brought the former Google engineer and serial entrepreneur back to the roots that helped launch his pioneering and controversial career — is starting to pay off.

Pronto, the San Francisco-based startup Levandowski co-founded with Ognjen Stojanovski, has developed a self-driving system designed for haulage trucks and other off-road vehicles that are

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used at construction and mining sites. About a dozen companies are now using its “autonomous haulage system” or AHS, according to Levandowski, who noted that not all of those deployments are driverless.

A newly announced partnership illustrates Pronto’s traction in the niche market. Pronto exclusively shared with TechCrunch that it has extended a partnership with Heidelberg Materials North

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“Obviously, autonomous vehicle technology is going to be transformational for all applications that have wheels, but I think that they’re going to come sooner in the applications where the technology and the market needs it and really lines up,” he said in a recent interview.



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Levandowski first formed Pronto in 2018 with a different aim. The startup was initially working on advanced driver assistance features built for Class 8 trucks and passenger vehicles.

Pronto pivoted to off-road autonomy in 2019 because "it became clear we couldn't do on-road

autonomy on a timeframe that we want as a business.”

The move brought him back to where he started.

Levandowski participated in the autonomous-driving Grand Challenge in 2005, an off-road AV competition sponsored by the DARPA. His experience — and the connections he made, including with Stanford professor and eventual



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Anthony's Robots, in 2011. He would later become a central figure in a trade secrets lawsuit that pitted the Alphabet subsidiary against Uber.

“I like off-road because that’s where you can build a product and you’re ready for today,” Levandowski said. “The market is obviously much, much smaller than on-road and typically, investors will want to chase a large TAM [total addressable market].”

Pronto has raised an undisclosed amount from investors, Levandowski said without naming his backers. He added the funding wasn't through a traditional VC series round.

"I don't think it's like the next frontier," he said of off-road autonomy. "It's almost like the skipped-over frontier that we really should have checked off along the way to on-road autonomy."

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Levandowski's Pronto.ai plans to ship automated driving systems for trucks in 2019



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first to report on details of the company and its cross-country autonomous drive, which was conducted in a modified Toyota Prius using only cameras, computers and basic digital maps. Levandowski says the autonomous car drove by itself the entire 3,100-mile trip without any human intervention.

TRANSPORTATION



Foxconn sells former GM factory to mystery buyer after failing to make EVs

Sean O'Kane - 3 days ago

Here's [the time-lapsed video](#) of the journey. (Note the speed at which the vehicle is traveling at different spots like the Golden Gate Bridge.)

Back in July, TechCrunch reported that his company was called Kache.ai, according to paperwork registering it as a corporation filed with the California Secretary of State. That name has apparently changed to Pronto.ai, according to Levandowski, who posted a [blog Tuesday on Medium](#).

Stojanovic, a scholar at the company, headed the autonomous vehicle project. He founded the company, which was subsequently acquired by Google.

Levandowski, who founded the autonomous vehicle company, largely ignored the technology. "I don't like LiDAR," he said. "These projects are vehicle projects, not computer projects." He predicted that autonomous vehicles would be a reality by 2025, but has also said that he doesn't see them in the near future.

"We need regulatory changes to get to the reality that nobody is ahead in the race to deliver autonomous vehicles because the real race is a marathon that has not yet begun," Levandowski wrote. "The last 15 years we've mostly idled at the starting line."



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platform agnostic, according to the company. Pronto will announce its first customers in the first half of 2019. The company is offering this at a “special introductory pricing” of \$4,999 per truck, a figure that includes bolt-on installation of its camera-based system, driver training and more. Pronto’s website says customers can pre-order with a deposit of \$299.

“It will be the first stand-alone real product for a

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